

Diabetes and Digestion



Healthy digestion and turning food into energy

To understand [diabetes](#), it helps to know how the body digests food and turns it into energy from the foods and drinks we have each day.

1. The digestive system breaks food and drinks down into nutrients your body can use.
2. Foods like bread, rice, pasta, milk and fruit contain carbohydrates. These are broken down into sugar called glucose. Glucose travels through the bloodstream and is used by your cells for energy. This energy helps with everything your body does like moving, thinking, growing and healing.
3. When blood sugar rises after eating, the pancreas makes a hormone called insulin. Insulin acts like a key, helping glucose move from the blood into the cells so your body can use it for energy. If it isn't needed right away, the body stores it for later use.

In people living with diabetes, this system doesn't work the way it should. This can happen in two main ways:

1. Not enough insulin. The pancreas doesn't make enough insulin, so glucose builds up in the blood.
2. Insulin resistance. The body makes insulin, but the cells don't respond to it well. They don't take in glucose like they should, causing blood sugar levels to rise.

When blood sugar stays high, the body cannot use energy properly and health problems can develop over time.

People living with diabetes may notice the following symptoms:

- Urinating more often, especially at night
- Feeling very thirsty
- Losing weight without trying
- Feeling hungrier than usual
- Changes in vision
- Numbness or tingling in hands or feet
- Feeling very tired
- Dry skin
- Cuts or sores that heal slowly
- Frequent infections

Some people may have few or no symptoms, especially early on.

If blood sugar rises to very high levels, more serious symptoms may occur, including:

- Nausea or vomiting
- Stomach pain
- Fruity-smelling breath
- Confusion or trouble thinking clearly
- Feeling disoriented
- Drowsiness
- Loss of consciousness (coma)
- Seizures

If these symptoms occur, medical care is needed right away.

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